01 - USER RESEARCH STRATEGY

KIABI 360° Framework

1. Project Context

KIABI's project materials identify online fitting as a weak journey stage: satisfaction is 13% (3/10), versus 75% (8/10) in store. Item-return rates are 26.5% online and 3.7% in store. Fit-related return causes are not confirmed. Fittybird x Kiabi proposes photo-based virtual try-on, with a web-first direction and a later store pilot (00-bootstrap/01-data-analysis.docx; 1a-product-manifesto/product-manifesto.docx).

The research should test what customers need and where uncertainty occurs, not presume that fit causes returns or that a digital tool will solve the problem. Online research and payment are comparatively strong; fitting is weak. Return costs and causes remain open data requests. The project therefore proposes web-first exploration before a possible store pilot (00-bootstrap/03-growth-levers-and-web-first.docx).

Interviews will investigate the behaviours and contexts behind these documented journey patterns, then inform later product decisions without treating the proposed solution as validated.

2. Research Problem Statement

The research problem is to understand how customers judge product fit and size online, what influences purchase or return decisions, and how customers move between online and store journeys. Fit-related return causes remain unverified.

What is already known from KIABI's documents:

- Online fitting has the lowest satisfaction score of the online journey: 13% satisfaction and a grade of 3/10 (00-bootstrap/01-data-analysis.docx).
- Online item-return rate is 26.5%, compared with 3.7% in store (00-bootstrap/01-data-analysis.docx).
- Fitting is the main point of weakness in the online journey, while in-store fitting is already comparatively strong (00-bootstrap/02-journey-maps.docx).
- Customers are not only returning more online; the value exposed per online cart is higher than in store, although the available analysis uses assumptions to estimate value exposure and does not establish that returned items were wrong-sized (00-bootstrap/01-data-analysis.docx).
- Kiabi has an NFC loyalty-card infrastructure, but the brief states that it currently only counts visits and is not yet meaningfully used as a true cross-channel customer link (360framework-bootstrap.pdf; 00-bootstrap/01-data-analysis.docx).
- Kiabi's macro trends and project brief point toward customer experience, cross-channel value, and digital innovation as strategic levers (00-bootstrap/03-growth-levers-and-web-first.docx; 360framework-project.pdf).

What remains unknown:

- Which factors drive a customer to buy online despite uncertainty about fit.
- Which return reasons are primarily caused by size or fit, as opposed to quality, style, or other reasons.
- Why some customers still prefer in-store research or experience, and what they find exhausting or frustrating about the physical journey.
- How customers experience the transition between online and store channels.
- Which obstacles prevent a loyalty-card or account-based omnichannel journey from feeling useful to customers.
- What confidence or reassurance customers need before they feel comfortable making a purchase decision.
- What operational realities affect staff and store workflows when customers ask for help or alternative sizes.

What needs to be investigated through customer interviews:

- Real customer motivations and purchase decisions.
- Product and size decision criteria during online browsing and in-store selection.

- Emotional and practical frustrations related to fit uncertainty, size differences, and returns.
- Customer expectations regarding trust, privacy, convenience, and digital assistance.
- The role of store staff, digital touchpoints, and loyalty-card behaviour in shaping channel transitions.
- Customer reactions to the idea of an avatar-based fit support, without assuming that the proposed concept is understood or accepted by default.

3. Research Objectives

The research objectives are to establish evidence on the customer context before any product decisions are treated as fixed. The objectives are as follows:

- Understand online shopping behaviour and how customers choose garments before purchase.
- Understand physical-store shopping behaviour and the in-store decision-making process when customers look for fit, choice, and efficiency.
- Investigate omnichannel customer journeys, including how customers move between online and physical-store experiences.
- Identify difficulties related to product discovery, availability, sizing, and product matching.
- Understand customer frustrations, expectations, and sources of uncertainty throughout the purchase journey.
- Explore how customers move between online and physical stores, and under what conditions they switch channels.
- Understand relevant employee experiences and operational challenges, especially where staff support or in-store workflows influence the customer journey.

4. Research Questions

The interview programme should be guided by neutral, open questions grouped around the customer journey and operational realities. The following research questions structure the investigation:

4.1 Customer shopping habits

- How do customers decide when to shop for clothing, and how often do they buy online, in store, or through both channels?
- What does a typical shopping trip look like for different customers?
- Which channels are preferred and why?
- What factors make a customer feel confident or uncertain in a purchase decision?

4.2 Product discovery

- How do customers discover products in Kiabi's online and store journeys?
- Which information helps them decide whether to browse, shortlist, or purchase an item?
- How important is visual presentation, fit information, and size confidence in product selection?

4.3 Online shopping experience

- What do customers find easy or frustrating when shopping online?
- How do they currently judge fit before purchasing?
- What information about size, product fit, or body shape would help them feel more confident?
- What are their main concerns before placing an order?

4.4 Physical-store experience

- What do customers value most when shopping in a physical Kiabi store?
- What makes an in-store trip feel efficient, pleasant, or frustrating?
- How do customers handle a product that may not fit correctly when in the store?
- What role do store staff and shop layout play in the shopping experience?

4.5 Stock and size availability

- How often do customers encounter stock or size gaps?
- What happens when a preferred item is unavailable in the desired size?
- How do customers adapt when the product they want is not available in the store or online?
- What impact does size availability have on customer trust and satisfaction?

4.6 Online-to-store transitions

- What motivates a customer to continue their journey online or in store?
- How do customers currently use loyalty cards, store visits, online accounts, or digital touchpoints across channels?
- What would make a cross-channel experience feel coherent and useful?
- What kinds of information should follow the customer from one channel to another?

4.7 Purchase experience

- What makes a customer feel ready to purchase?
- Which moments in the journey create hesitation or second thoughts?
- What features or support would reduce doubt before a transaction is completed?

4.8 Returns and post-purchase experience

- What are the main reasons customers return items?
- How do customers feel when an item does not fit as expected?
- What would reduce friction for customers after purchase?
- What return experiences are considered acceptable or frustrating?

5. Research Methodology

Use exploratory, qualitative, semi-structured interviews to understand real behaviour before validating product assumptions. Apply open, neutral questions, active listening, probing, and traceable notes. The standalone EPITECH interview presentation was not available in the repository reviewed.

The methodology will include:

- Qualitative research: interviews are the primary source of evidence because the project revolves around emotional, behavioural, and contextual questions.
- Semi-structured interviews: each discussion will follow a flexible guide with core topics and optional follow-up questions, allowing the participant to express their experience naturally.
- Active listening: the researcher will listen carefully to what is said without interrupting the customer's narrative, giving space for unprompted information.
- Open-ended questions: interviews will use broad questions that allow participants to explain decisions, frustrations, and expectations in their own terms.
- Probing and follow-up questions: clarifying questions will be used when relevant, particularly to understand cause, sequence, pain points, and context.
- Avoiding leading questions: the interviewer will avoid suggesting a desired answer or framing the product too early.
- Neutrality and observation: the researcher will record customer behaviour, wording, non-verbal cues, emotions, and uncertainty without injecting personal assumptions.
- Recording customer experiences: field notes, summaries, and structured observations will be captured systematically so that evidence can be traced back to the participant and the specific stage of the journey.

This approach is suitable because project metrics identify journey gaps, while their causes, customer explanations, and channel behaviours still need validation.

6. Research Scope

The research scope will cover the groups that matter most to the problem and the product context. The scope is intentionally centred on the Kiabi customer ecosystem and the operational realities around its shopping journey.

6.1 Online customers

- Shoppers who purchase via Kiabi's e-commerce or mobile journey.
- Focus on product discovery, fit confidence, checkout confidence, and return behaviour.
- Investigate where the customer feels uncertainty, especially around size decisions.

6.2 Physical-store customers

- Shoppers who experience Kiabi's stores and fitting-cabin process.
- Focus on item search, fit evaluation, shopping efficiency, interaction with staff, and satisfaction with the in-store journey.
- Investigate whether the store experience reduces or increases frustration compared with the online journey.

6.3 Omnichannel customers

- Customers who move between online and in-store journeys, including those using loyalty cards, digital assets, or click-and-collect-type paths.
- Focus on continuity, data use, expectations, and cross-channel friction.
- Identify whether customers see the online and physical experiences as one journey or as separate journeys.

6.4 Sales assistants

- Store staff who support customers in cabinet or checkout environments.
- Focus on their observations of customer frustrations, the usefulness of digital tools, and the operational friction created by product sizing, requests, or follow-up interactions.

6.5 Store managers

- People responsible for operational execution, deployment, and local customer experience.
- Focus on which in-store processes are working, which routines are painful, and what a pilot scenario would need from the operational side.

The research scope therefore covers both customer-facing and staff-facing realities, which is important because Kiabi's data indicates a business opportunity but also tells us that the operational environment must be considered when designing a real solution.

7. Research Hypotheses

The following unverified hypotheses should guide interview planning and analysis.

H1. Customers struggle to judge fit online because product photos and size charts do not provide enough confidence.

- **Why it matters:** This is the central pain point identified by Kiabi's dashboard and the product brief.
- **Evidence available:** Online fitting satisfaction is 13%; return rate is 26.5%.
- **What needs validation:** Whether customers actually rely on visual fit, size charts, or social proof before purchasing.

H2. Size and fit uncertainty is the main reason for online returns.

- **Why it matters:** It links customer behaviour to the business problem.
- **Evidence available:** Online returns are much higher than store returns and fitting is the weakest online stage.
- **What needs validation:** The share of returns caused by fit, size, or product mismatch.

H3. In-store customers do not feel the same pain as online customers because the physical environment reduces uncertainty.

- **Why it matters:** This explains why the store journey is comparatively stronger.
- **Evidence available:** In-store fitting satisfaction is 75% versus 13% online.
- **What needs validation:** Whether customers actually feel more confident in store and what aspects of the in-store journey create that confidence.

H4. Customers want a better size decision process, not necessarily a more complex product exploration flow.

- **Why it matters:** The research should not assume the value proposition is only digital novelty.
- **Evidence available:** Kiabi data and product background point to fit and size as the main issue.
- **What needs validation:** Which information customers need to feel confident before they buy.

H5. Omnichannel customers expect continuity between online and physical touchpoints.

- **Why it matters:** Cross-channel profitability is higher, and the project intentionally includes a later in-store pilot.
- **Evidence available:** Cross-channel customer is 3x more profitable; NFC is underused.
- **What needs validation:** Whether customers see a real benefit in the same account, same avatar, or same size profile across channels.

H6. The loyalty card and identity link are not yet creating customer value.

- **Why it matters:** This is a key product and business risk in the current corporate context.
- **Evidence available:** The brief states the NFC tag only counts entries; it is not yet exploited.
- **What needs validation:** Whether customers value a linked customer identity or see it as irrelevant or intrusive.

H7. Operational staff can play a meaningful role in the in-store pilot, but this needs validation.

- **Why it matters:** Store actors are part of the journey and the later pilot.
- **Evidence available:** The fitting-cabin screen and staff tablet flow already exist in Kiabi stores.
- **What needs validation:** Whether staff and customers would find the service useful, and where it creates friction or value.

H8. Customer privacy and trust are sensitive topics for a photo-based fit experience.

- **Why it matters:** This is a product-risk issue and may influence adoption.
- **Evidence available:** The product manifesto and risk management files note privacy and trust concerns.
- **What needs validation:** What customers need to feel comfortable sharing photos and using a digital body model.

8. Research Process

The research process should be structured and traceable. The workflow is as follows:

Distinguish customer needs from product assumptions and connect evidence to probable opportunity areas.

Share the patterns, evidence, and open questions that guide next design and product decisions.

9. Expected Deliverables

The research workstream should produce separate documents, each with a distinct purpose. The expected deliverables are:

- Stakeholder Map.
- Participant Recruitment Plan.
- Interview Guides.
- Interview Records.
- Interview Analysis.
- Empathy Maps.

- Customer Journey Maps.
- Research Findings Report.

These are separate outputs from the detailed product artefacts such as personas, backlog, or architecture, and should remain anchored in raw customer evidence and observation.

10. Research Quality and Ethics

Research quality must be preserved through careful process discipline and ethical practice.

- Neutrality: the researcher must keep the interviews focused on customer experience rather than on validating a predetermined product idea.
- Reliable evidence: findings should be traceable to recorded interview material, not assumptions or informal interpretation.
- Confidentiality: customer information must be stored and handled responsibly, especially since body-image and fit concerns are involved.
- Informed consent: participants should understand why the research is being conducted, how their data will be used, and that they can withdraw if appropriate.
- Accurate documentation: notes and findings must be written clearly and without reinterpretation.
- Separation of facts and interpretations: direct observations, statements, and inferred conclusions should be kept distinct.
- Awareness of limitations and bias: the project team should recognise that interview evidence is qualitative and cannot replace broader data validation or later product testing.

11. My Role and Responsibilities

As the User Research and Interview Methodology Specialist, my role is to ensure that customer evidence is gathered, structured, and communicated in a way that can inform product decisions without forcing a solution prematurely.

My responsibilities include:

- Plan exploratory research and prioritise relevant stakeholders and participants.
- Prepare neutral interview guides and conduct interviews using active listening and probing.
- Document interviews and maintain traceable, structured research evidence.
- Analyse recurring themes, customer needs, and operational constraints.
- Develop empathy maps and customer journey maps from the evidence.
- Communicate insights and keep product decisions grounded in research.

12. Research Success Criteria

Research succeeds when it produces relevant, traceable evidence across key stakeholder groups, identifies recurring discovery, fit, and return issues, and informs problem framing and product hypotheses.

- Coverage of the major stakeholder groups relevant to the journey.
- Quality and relevance of interview evidence.
- Identification of recurring customer problems in product discovery, fit, and returns.
- Clear traceability between findings and source evidence.
- Useful communication of insight to the team.
- Ability to support future decisions on problem framing, scope, and product hypotheses.

Research is complete when traceable evidence explains key experiences and friction points well enough to inform decisions, not merely when interviews have taken place.

13. Open Questions and Limitations

Key data and access gaps remain:

- The exact value of one avoided return remains to be clarified with Kiabi.
- Return reason codes, including the share caused by fit or size, are still missing from the available data and must be requested.

- Online order volume, conversion rates, and pilot sizing assumptions still need confirmation.
- Size charts and the exact pilot article data are required before deeper fit analysis can be fully operationalised.
- The role owner has accepted the User Research and Interview Methodology Specialist role; team sign-off remains pending in the project decision log.
- Not all customer segments are covered in the initial version of the personas; some groups remain outside the first pilot focus.
- The research will be exploratory and qualitative, so its findings must be validated later with broader data, usability testing, and pilot measurement.

14. References

The strategy uses repository project documents and the assignment-provided research brief. The original bootstrap and EPITECH helper presentations cited in earlier drafts were not present in the repository review; see the methodology and limitations sections for this source boundary.

- 00-bootstrap/01-data-analysis.docx – dashboard-derived metrics, item-return figures, assumptions, and open data requests.
- 2a-personas/personas.docx – user-type hypotheses with source notes and validation needs.
- README.docx and A-roadmap/roadmap.docx – project checkpoints and rollout context.
- 00-bootstrap/01-data-analysis.docx – data analysis of online and store journeys, sales, returns, and fit issues.
- 00-bootstrap/02-journey-maps.docx – online and in-store journey maps and pain points.
- 00-bootstrap/03-growth-levers-and-web-first.docx – growth levers and web-first deployment decision.
- 1a-product-manifesto/product-manifesto.docx – product framing and business rationale.
- 2a-personas/personas.docx – customer segments and user types.
- B-methodology/methodology.docx – project workflow and user-centred process; it does not replace the standalone EPITECH exploratory-interview presentation, which was not present in the repository.
- 00-bootstrap/02-journey-maps.docx – online and in-store journey stages and pain points.
- B-methodology/methodology.docx – product process, user-centred work, and project review practices.
- shared/glossary.docx – product terminology used across the project.

Conclusion

This document defines the research strategy for the KIABI 360° Framework project. It is intentionally focused on understanding the customer and the business problem before proposing or validating a solution. The research will investigate fit uncertainty, size confidence, channel transitions, operational realities, and customer trust through qualitative interviews and structured evidence gathering. The goal is to ensure that future product decisions are grounded in customer evidence and aligned with the project's business and strategic direction.